

UTT Chapter 07 Assignment

Hi there!

It's only eight p.m. here, but I'm so tired already! Some of the guys in my dorm decided it would be a fun prank to pull the fire alarm every night at two a.m. *Not* fun. Everyone has to leave the building even during false alarms, and it usually takes around half an hour for the firemen to check everything. I'm. So. Tired! They somehow haven't caught the perpetrators; it seems like they pull the alarm on different floors every night. I hope it stops soon.

Anyway, it's been a good week other than that. Nothing too eventful has happened, and I haven't had much homework, which is always nice. I had to write a big paper for my art class this week, which was fun since I wrote about the impressionists. I've always enjoyed their art. We're moving through the romantic period all the way up to the present. This week we studied postmodern art. I'm not sure how I feel about it. At first I wasn't impressed, but I think I'm warming up to some of the works. Postmodern art is basically a reaction to modern art, which was all about structure and getting down to the foundations of art itself—stripping away everything that distracts from the main message of the piece. Postmodern art challenges the very definition of art itself. A lot of artists just put junk on a pedestal and call it art. One guy even took a urinal, signed it, and called it "Fountain." Seems kind of disgusting to me, but it's displayed in a museum somewhere. I guess if it gets people talking, then that's something.

Paige, a friend of mine from class, is really into postmodern art. She says that labels and definitions for things that are "art" and things that are "junk" are just that—labels. Everything is sacred, and nothing is sacred. She believes that since reality is fragmented and chaotic, art should display the same attitude. Since there's no definition of what makes us human, or what makes a thing a "thing," art should reflect this. My head is spinning just trying to make sense of everything!

I guess Postmodernism isn't just about art. After class, Paige told me a little bit about Postmodernism. I guess it's a worldview, or at least she made it seem that way. I was able to follow a little of what she said, but I must admit, I was mostly lost. **What is Postmodernism?** She apparently doesn't believe in human nature, but I'm not sure how to even make sense of that. **What does Postmodernism say about humanity?** I'm guessing that Postmodernism doesn't believe in the fall, so **what does Postmodernism say is wrong with us?** Sadly, we didn't get a chance to talk about ethics at all. **What does Postmodernism say about how we should live?** From the way Paige was talking, I wouldn't be surprised if you couldn't answer these questions in a way that makes sense. It doesn't seem like anything she said was coherent!

Once again, thanks for your help! You're the best worldview dictionary a friend can have.

Talk to you later!

–Doug

Doug brought up four different questions; below is a rough outline of possible responses:

1. What is Postmodernism?

Postmodernism literally means “after modernism.” It began as a reaction to modernism—a belief that science, human reason, progress, and technology could reveal truth—but emerged as a philosophy that denies the truth claims made by all worldviews. According to Postmodernism, worldviews like modernism, Marxism, and Christianity merely trick us into thinking they have access to objective truth when no worldview has direct access to the world as it actually is. All of us formulate beliefs based upon our own situatedness, that is, our own experiences, language, locality, culture, and so on. What we think of as “truth” is always subjective and biased. Postmodernism can be summed up as a rejection of universal truth, common reason, objective knowledge, metanarratives, and objectivity. [7.2]

2. What does Postmodernism say about humanity?

Human nature is just a myth, according to Postmodernism. There is no essence that makes us who we are. There is no self-identity, central personality, or permanent soul. We don’t exist as persons; we are merely subjects existing as a “collage of social constructs.” How we view ourselves is shaped by our own ever-changing experiences, and how others view us is shaped by their ever-changing understanding. All experience and understanding is shaped by the unavoidable situatedness of human existence. In the end, we are ever-evolving, highly sexual, social animals with multiple subjective interests (**multiple selves**) vying for our allegiance. [7.7b]

3. What does Postmodernism say is wrong with us?

According to Postmodernism, the central problem of humanity is that we believe the lies sold to us by competing metanarratives. Because human beings sense that something is wrong, we lean on grand stories for solutions. Christians live as if creation is fallen and Christ is the redeemer. Marxists believe that socio-economic conditions are the root cause, and solution for, human suffering. Secularists look toward science and progress for humanity’s salvation. According to the Postmodernism, believing that any worldview can lead us to the truth is false belief and one that enables powerful people to control us. [7.7c]

4. What does Postmodernism say about how we should live?

Postmodernists advocate abandoning the search for objective truth in favor of a search for the pragmatic. Truth isn’t something that we discover out there; it is something that resides within us. We just need to construct it.

Instead of arguing with each other over which metanarrative accurately depicts an inaccessible reality, we should use our collective experiences to generate a theory for living together. Since reality doesn't exist outside the boundaries of language and culture, we should use ideas like we use tools—to construct a reality in which we can all get along. [7.7d]